

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

7-0(A)

Rcd 2/2/01 upsl

PHILADELPHIA VIREO
Vireo philadelphicus

Location: Crystal Lake; in Rocky Ford; Otero County, Colorado

Date: October 1, 2000

Brandon Percival and I were birding the Crystal Lake area in Rocky Ford as a last stop on a southeastern birding trip. Brandon found the bird along the top of the dike at 5:00 p.m. The bird was moving slowly through the treetops (elm, cottonwood) that grew along the base of the dike. Thus it was at, or just above, eye level for us. None-the-less it was difficult to observe as it was slow moving and kept to heavy foliage and branch tips. We succeeded in getting excellent views and observed it for about 30 minutes, off and on. It was sunny and conditions were very good. I watched it from about 25-50 feet distance with my B & L Elite 10x42 binoculars.

Description:

It was an adult bird, medium-sized, about 5" long. It was about the size of a Warbling Vireo, but the shape was a little different as its tail was quite short compared to that species. In general aspect it was stubby, short-tailed and rather bull-headed. The bill was small, but it was quite stout proportionately, dark, strong, blunt and slightly hooked, and not pointed like a warbler bill. The bird was subtly colored in grays, pale green-grays, pale yellows and off white. The crown was gray, barely contrasting with the greenish-gray back and wings. There were no wingbars. There was fairly faint, white, curved supercilium. There was a diffuse, blackish line from the bill to just through the eye. The bird was distinctly yellow underneath, especially in the throat and breast. The undertail coverts were paler yellow.

Similar Species:

The small size, slender build, small bill and general coloration and pattern indicate a warbler or vireo. Warblers have slender, sharp bills that lack the blunt tip of this bird's bill. The contrasting gray crown, dark line through the eye and lack of wingbars eliminate Bell's Vireo. Warbling Vireo is most similar, but it has light lores, and lacks the yellow center to the breast and throat; has a longer tail.

Experience with Species:

I have seen all of the Colorado vireos and most warblers. I have seen several Philadelphia Vireos in other states and four times before in Colorado.

This report was prepared from notes made immediately after observation.

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